

Over the years, changes in public awareness have led to a renewed interest in herbal medicine. In fact, some herbal preparations are now so commonly used that they are accepted as a part of everyday life. One of many possible examples is evening primrose oil, which is used by hundreds of thousands of women in Britain to help relieve premenstrual syndrome. It is extracted from the seeds of *Oenothera biennis* (p. 241), a North American plant. Peppermint oil (*Mentha x piperita*, p. 114), prescribed for irritable bowel syndrome and other gut problems, is another example, while senna (*Cassia senna*, p. 75), a simple, effective treatment for short-term constipation, is one of the most frequently used medicines throughout the world.

The growing awareness of how our lives as human beings are interwoven with the fate of our planet also reinforces the value of herbal medicines. As long as care is taken to prevent overharvesting, herbal medicine is ecologically in tune with the environment.

Herbalism & Holism

The “germ theory of disease,” which holds that illness springs from contact with an infectious organism, remains the dominant view in mainstream medicine. Many people, however, recognize that this is only part of the picture. While illnesses such as cholera and typhoid are highly infectious and are indeed likely to be caught by almost anyone, many infectious diseases are not transmitted automatically from one person to another. The question arises, therefore, what weakness in the patient has allowed the “seed” of infection to find fertile ground? Unlike much conventional medical practice, which focuses on eradicating the “bug” or abnormal condition, herbal medicine seeks to treat the weakness that gave rise to ill health, and sets this in the context of the patient’s life as a whole. A complex web of factors may lie behind the onset of illness. While bodily signs and symptoms are the most obvious indicators, dietary, emotional, and spiritual factors may be of equal importance.

Our bodies contain over one hundred trillion cells, which collectively must function in harmony if good health is to be maintained. Used wisely, herbs work in tune with our bodies, stimulating, supporting, or restraining different sets of cells in their allotted tasks within the body, encouraging a return to normal balanced function. Remedies aim to strengthen the patient’s own resistance, improve the vitality of weakened tissue, and encourage the body’s innate ability to return to good health.

Of course, for people with severe acute illnesses, it may be too late to use an herbal approach to treatment. In these circumstances, strong-acting conventional medicines such as heart drugs, antibiotics, and painkillers, as well as surgery, can all be lifesavers. However, a health-care system that is carefully attuned to the needs of the patient might well



Evening primrose is native to North America and has been used to treat a wide range of conditions, including premenstrual syndrome, asthma, whooping cough, digestive disorders, and eczema.

provide herbal remedies as a first line of treatment, with conventional medicines held in reserve to be used only when necessary.

Evidence in Support of Herbal Cures

Many medical scientists still find it hard to accept that natural medicines, with their complex chemical makeup and variable constituents, can be as good as chemical cures in treating illness. However, as more and more research reveals that herbal medicines can be as effective as conventional medicines—and are far safer—this thinking is beginning to change.

This is well illustrated by the change in attitude toward St. John’s wort (*Hypericum perforatum*, p. 106)—a European plant commonly taken as an antidepressant. Extracts of the herb are now scientifically recognized as having value in mild to moderate depression. Since the 1980s, over 30 clinical trials have found extracts of St. John’s wort to be as effective as conventional antidepressants and to have far fewer side effects. In 15 of these trials, the herbal extract produced fewer side effects than the placebo (or inert “medicine”) used as a comparison. Other investigations suggest that St. John’s wort may have a role in countering viral infections, promoting wound healing, and helping withdrawal from addiction, especially from alcohol.

As is so often the case, research has confirmed traditional views. In the 16th century, Paracelsus (see p. 23) had this to say about the herb: “Nothing chases away disease like strength. Therefore, we should seek medicines with power and strength to overcome whatever illnesses they are used against. From this it follows that God has given to Perforatum [St. John’s wort] the strength to chase [away] the ghosts of nature...and all downheartedness.”

As a result of scientific research, today’s practitioners have an important advantage—how the plant works in the body is